CREDO QUIA ABSURDUM

E Clampus Vitus on Paper

The ancient and honorable order, from its first appearance in print in 1846 to its fifty-one chapters today

1845–1851

Before California

c.1845	Ephraim Bee of West Union, Virginia, receives his commission, says the story. LEGEND
1846	February: a Connersville, Indiana, letter jokes of "the 'Eclampsus Vitus' society, an order of which, we have in our town." The earliest dated record.
1846	Spring: a lodge at Cassopolis, Michigan. Charter members Dr. E. J. Bonine, Laban Harter, J. P. Osborn and Dr. L. Osborn.
1846	July: "Tent No. 43 of the order of Eclampsus Vitus" meets at Indianapolis, "attired in full regalia."
1847	January: the Indiana House tables a bill to incorporate Jackson Lodge of Centreville, for the benefit of "a species of animals" it does not wish to "improve the breed" of.
1847	The Cassopolis ball of the winter just past had "over two hundred badges." At Bedford, Pennsylvania, a lodge meets by one tallow candle under a brown-paper hat.
1849	Division No. 110 keeps a record book at Metropolis, Illinois. The ritual is printed at the Bowling Green Journal, Missouri.

1852–1915

The Gold-Rush Order

1852	March: "the new order introduced recently into Virginia" is dog Latin, says Alexandria, for "squeezing the life out of you."
1852	April: the members of the E. C. V. are called to their hall at Stockton. The earliest California record; David Lodge No. 1. May: a Sanhedrim at San Antonio, Texas.
1853	The lodge at Murphys gives $150 toward a school, and meets over Buffum's saloon.
1855	Sacramento initiates "nearly five hundred persons ... within three weeks." Lodges from Weaverville to Shasta.
1856	Steamboat Jake is initiated at Yreka. NOT 1852
1857	The ritual sold by mail: "$5 per set of three." The Hall of Comparative Ovations is named in print.
1867	Bee initiates at Wheeling, "the recognized American head" of the order.
1884	"The Royal Platrix has sounded the hewgag" at Sierraville.
1896	Lord Sholto Douglas is initiated at Marysville.
1904	A newspaperman "danced the dance that David danced" at Moses Lodge, Sierraville.
1915	Marysville incorporates the order.

1931–TODAY

Revived

1931	Carl I. Wheat, G. Ezra Dane and Leon O. Whitsell revive the order at the Clift Hotel, San Francisco. Yerba Buena No. 1. Adam Lee Moore of Sierra City's Balaam Lodge brings the old ways.
1934	The Enigmatical Book of Vitus, the revival's first book.
1936	Drake's Plate of Brass is "found": a Clamper joke that fooled the experts for decades.
1939	Plaques: John M. Studebaker's at Placerville is dedicated in August. Today the Historical Marker Database lists 1,876 in the order's series; at least 149 California Historical Landmarks bear its hand.
1966	Then and Now hopes that "some day someone will ... compile a complete list" of the early lodges.
2026	The list: 61 places on record before 1905, each with its source. Fifty-one chapters in eleven western states.

Sources for every line, and the full register of early lodges: projectscroll.com/news/e-clampus-vitus-the-complete-record · Discovery and research by Michael Urbanski · Project Scroll, 2026. Dates are those of the earliest surviving record; "legend" marks a date no record supports.

Satisfactory!